and money. If I can achieve that, then I am through."

His line-up after *12th Fail* is proof of how he's now being offered meatier leading parts. There's what's poised to be a hard-hitting drama in *The Sabarmati Report*; a love story *Aankhon ki Gustaakhiyan*; a web series with Rajkumar Hirani and more films which he isn't allowed to disclose. "I want people to associate me with emotions and quality," he says. "I am in a position where I am yet to gain their trust. I have to be consistent enough."

Audiences will decide whether *Sector 36* is worth their time and money. Meanwhile, *12th Fail* doesn't leave him and is unlikely to until next year when it will be a prime contender for the National Awards. "I was anticipating it this year. *Mujhe toh chadha diya, kaisa lag raha hai aapko* [I have been put on a pedestal, how are you liking it?]. I just hope it's not jinxed now." Laurels, adulation, viewing numbers are far from his mind. Right now Massey's focus is on unnerving the audience with his cold-blooded killer act. ■

–Suhani Singh

CINEMA

BETTER LATE THAN NEVER

After a pandemic-induced hiatus, actor ***Sharvari*** *is riding high with several back-to-back releases—from* Munjya *to* Maharaj *and* Vedaa

Sharvari had it all figured out. She'd debut in a big web series, Kabir Khan's *The Forgotten Army* (Amazon Prime), and then make her big screen entry with Yash Raj's *Bunty Aur Babli 2*. But the Covid-19 pandemic played spoilsport. Both the series and the film failed to make an impression and for three years she disappeared off the screens. However, behind the scenes, Sharvari was patient and persevering. "Those three years were bittersweet. Bitter because I had to keep changing plans. And sweet because *Bunty Aur Babli 2* did get me meetings and auditions," she says.

All the hard work has paid off in 2024. In June came Sharvari's second release, *Munjya*, in which she's pursued by the titular scary spirit. It became a sleeper hit, entering the Rs 100 crore club. This was followed by a supporting part as the perky love interest to a brooding social reformer in *Maharaj* (on Netflix), and finally *Vedaa*, a social drama where she's a Dalit woman seeking justice. It's truly spring season for Sharvari as she also joins YRF's popular spy universe, starring alongside Alia Bhatt in *Alpha* (2025), the first female-centric film in the franchise. "It is such a big IP [intellectual property] in Bollywood and I'm the youngest actor to be attached, which is a big deal," she says. "*Alpha* is a film which breaks glass ceilings with two women doing action and being badass."

That's not a bad start for a 26-year-old outsider. While Sharvari doesn't come from a cinematic lineage, she is the granddaughter of late Maharashtra chief minister Manohar Joshi. As a child, she used to go see Marathi plays and films with her family, did acting workshops in summer, and performed in English musicals in school. This was enough to stoke her desire to be an actor. She began her cinematic journey behind the camera, assisting filmmakers Sanjay Leela Bhansali and Luv Ranjan.

Sharvari joins a micro league of Maharashtrian actors like Riteish Deshmukh who have found a footing in commercial Hindi cinema. *Munjya*'s success was special given it is based on Maharashtrian folklore. Says Sharvari, "I was happy someone was making a film rooted in my culture." *Munjya*'s success opened the floodgates of opportunities for her. "I am living my dream," she says. "But it's not that the apple has fallen in my hand. Now I have to prove myself more and go the extra mile." ■

–Suhani Singh



Sharvari joins a micro league of Maharashtrian actors who have found a footing in commercial Hindi cinema

MILIND SHELTE